

FUCEORUY Dance Mat

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Styling

Aesthetics

I Bet You Look Good On The Dancefloor



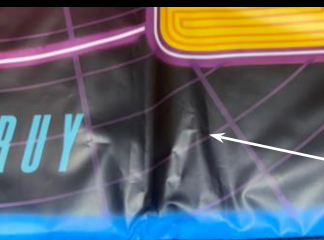
The artwork on the dance mat features **bright neon colours** on a black and purple background and has somewhat **retro disco vibes** (see mini-moodboard above [1]) as it tries to create a mini nightclub dancefloor in your front room! The controller features a volume dial, a 3-digit 7-segment display and 4 arrow icons surrounded by black reflective vinyl. The cyan controller housing and reflective black plastic around the screen are **consistent** with the colour theme of the product and do not detract from the visually **good impression of quality**. The 3-digit display is **basic but completely suitable** for the product and gives the user all the feedback necessary.

Visually, problems occur in bright light conditions as the 7-segment display is hard to see in **direct sunlight**. Conversely, in low light conditions, the LEDs behind the arrow icons are too bright and are **not diffused very well** (especially yellow) which is both **off-putting** and **uncomfortable** to look at.



Feel

Crinkly and creasy but good for kids



PEVA (shower curtain material) is used for the top of the dance mat, which provides a **smooth, non-absorbent, soft, wipeable** surface to dance on, but is also noticeably **crinkly and creases** easily when repeatedly folded for transport or storage.

Creases from folding

Blue injection moulded **ABS** is used to make the housing for the controller. This is not completely smooth and has an eggshell like finish which has the effect of **hiding scratches** and damage more effectively but feels less premium to the touch than a smooth finish. The housing feels **rigid** and **solid** and can survive being stood on or dropped.

The only hand control is a rotary switch with a blue plastic textured knob (on/off/volume control) which provides a **satisfying tactile feedback bump** when turning the dial on. A battery compartment on the back of the housing is covered by a plastic lid secured only with a snapping compliant mechanism which is well designed and **snaps firmly** into place.

Physically, the standout issues are the **crinkly creasy** nature of the mat material and the lack of **physical tactile feedback** when pressing a foot switch - the user must rely on audio-visual clues to know when a button has been stepped on. Overall, the product feels **well made, but not premium**.

Audio

A headache for the parents

2 **aggravatingly tinny speakers** are hidden inside the controller behind the perforated circular areas. These are undoubtedly the grievance of parents far and wide who have bought this dance mat as they can quickly go from a **whisper to an ear-splitting racket**. This is compounded by the set of 7 preloaded backing tracks which are **irritatingly repetitive**. The only slight mitigation is the 3.5mm audio jack present on the controller which allows your own choice of music to be played (even if it sounds terrible).

Despite this, there is likely little conflict with user expectations as a child will not be too bothered by the **shoddy sound quality** and instead focused on dancing!

Brand Image

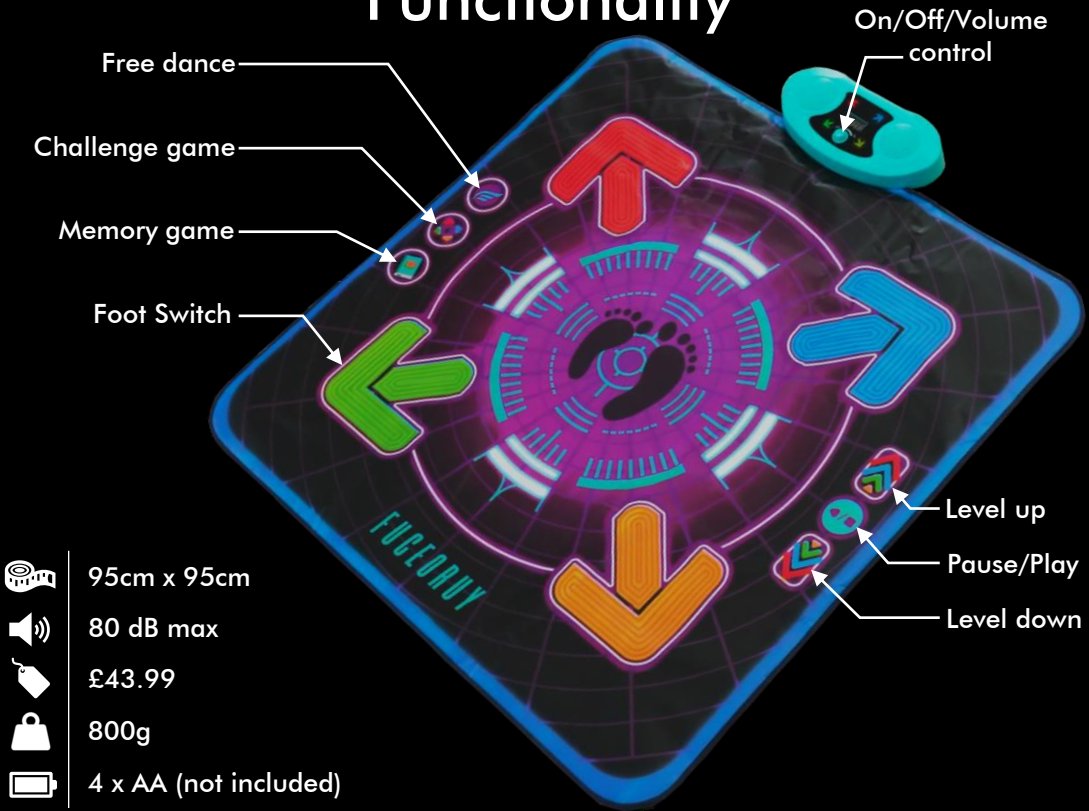
Copycat product - Stealing a slice of the pie

The Fuceoruy dance mat is a **copycat product** of the very successful Kidzlane dance mat (right [2]). Fuceoruy have copied the colour scheme and layout to try and exploit the strong brand image and perceived quality of the Kidzlane product whilst also undercutting the cost to increase their sales.

However, the Fuceoruy product is lacking key features of the Kidzlane dance mat that make it stand out as the leading product in the market. **Bluetooth connectivity, light up foot switches** and more controls on the side that make the Kidzlane dance mat a more premium product.



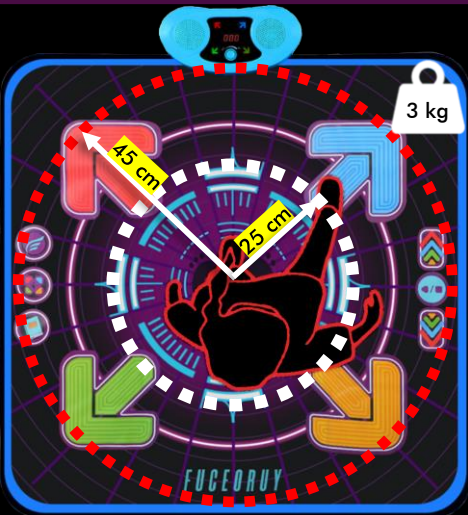
Functionality



Ergonomics

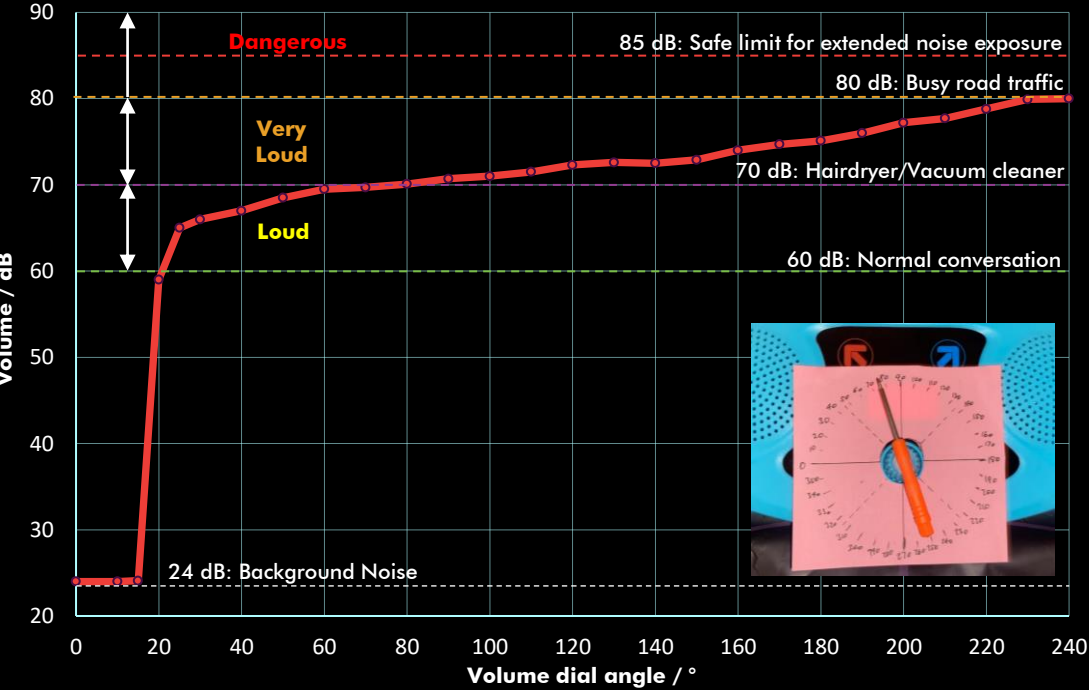
Designed for a child

From the centre of the mat, the shortest distance to a foot switch is **25cm**, and all foot controls can be reached within **45cm** (right [2]). The average step size of a 6-year-old is approximately 45cm [7] so the arrows are all easily within one step reach for most children, while the controls on the side may be a stretch for smaller children. Using a box with approximately the same surface area as a child's footprint (150cm²) between 2.3 – 3kg of weight was required to activate the pressure pads in the mat. The average weight for 6-year-old children is 20kg, meaning that these will be activated easily by any child dancing on the mat.



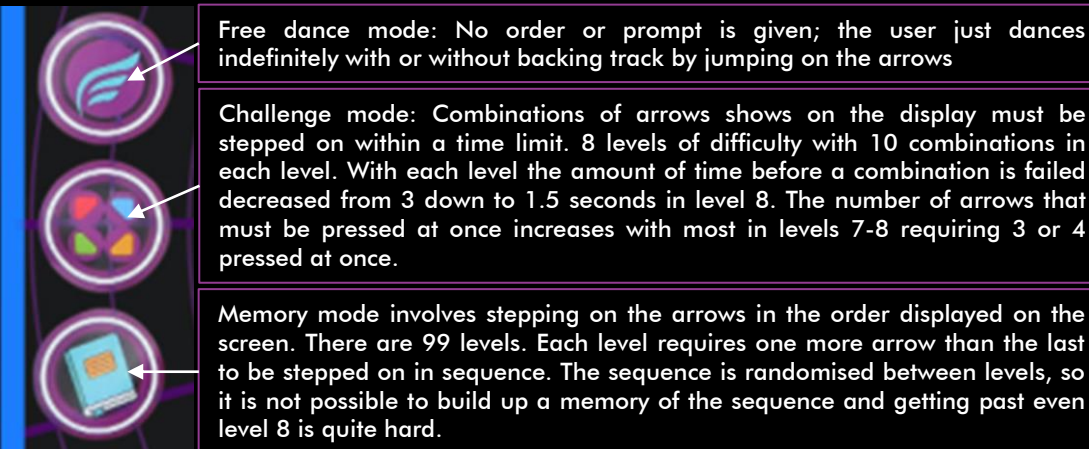
Controls

Volume sensitivity – Loud or louder?



The on/off rotary switch also acts as a volume dial. The volume control is **extremely sensitive** and quickly ramps up from talking to shouting volume with only minor adjustments to the dial. This was quantified by using a smartphone app to measure the sound level 1m above the mat (approximate height of a short 6-year-old) along with a makeshift protractor (shown). 10 dB is approximately double the perceived volume of sound. The sensitive range is mainly between 70 – 80 dB which makes it almost impossible to get the speakers to a level where you can comfortably talk to someone at the same time. Coupled with the poor quality of the speakers this makes for quite an irritating experience.

Dance Modes – Uninspiring but keeps kids entertained

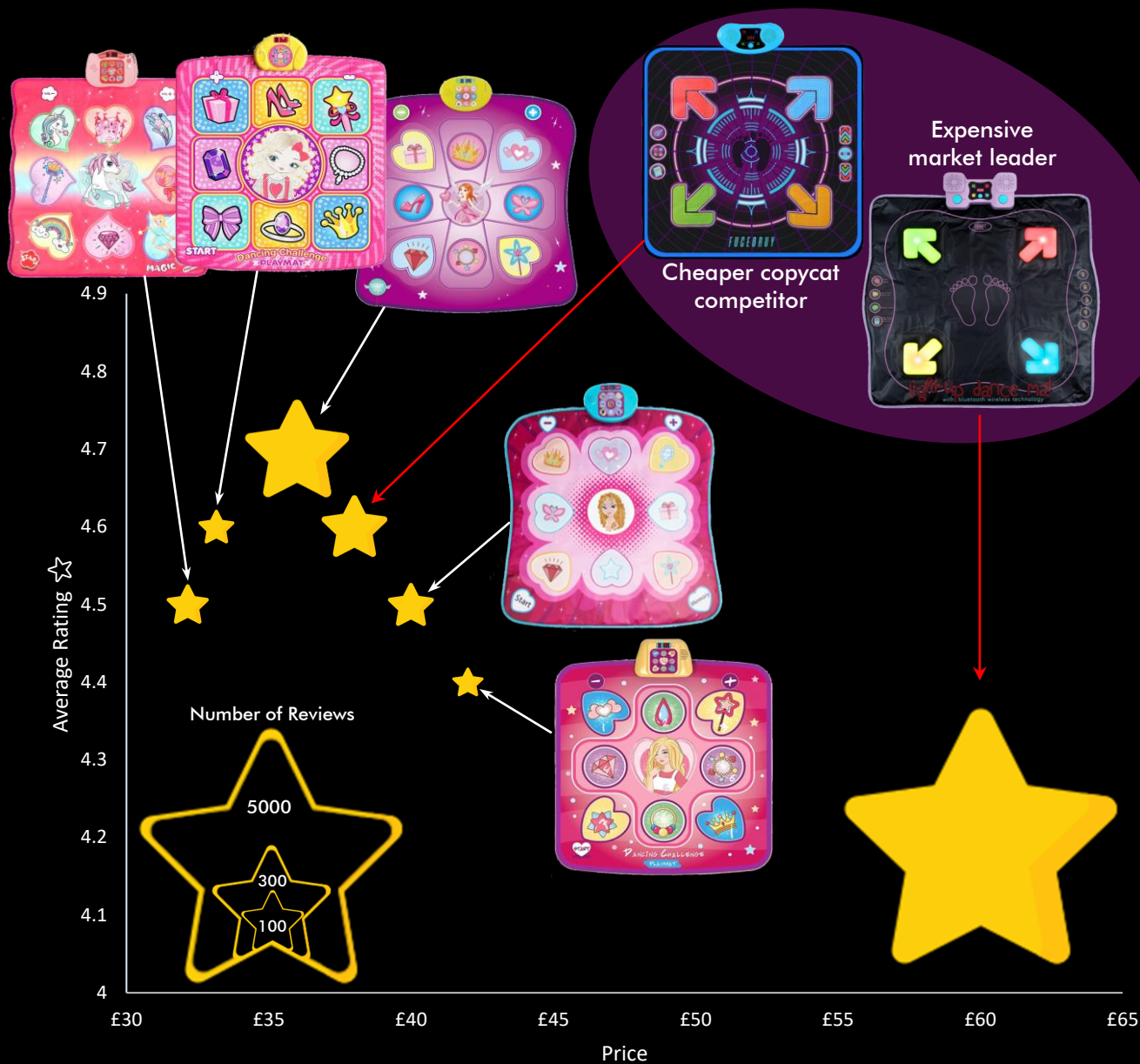


References
1. Moodboard images L-R from: freepik.com, vecteezy.com, locomocean.com, flickr.com/photos/ucluphotosoc
2. Images from Amazon.co.uk listings
3. Image: Lightning to 3.5mm Headphone Jack Adapter; apple.com
4. Images from alibaba.com/catalog/bluetooth-modules_cid201231005 - Bluetooth Audio Modules
5. Image from Farnell.com; Tactile Switch MCDTS2
6. Image of John Travolta in 'Saturday Night Fever', 1977, Paramount Pictures
7. 'Gait parameters in a sample of children aged between 6 and 12', Thevenon et al., 2015, Physical and Rehabilitation Medicine

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Market Comparison

Competition

Copycat in a market flooded with clones

The Dance Mats section on Amazon is dominated by rebadged clones of the same design with varying visuals as shown [2]. They have the same button layout, size and are all a similar price. These are likely made by the same manufacturer and sold under different brand names on Amazon to increase the visibility of their products.

The Fuceoruy dance mat differs in layout, colour scheme and marketing to the other popular dance mats. Fuceoruy have made a **copycat product**, trying to build on the economic success and brand image of the Kidzlane dance mat – the most sold and reviewed dance mat on Amazon. In order to compete on price with the rebadged clones popular on Amazon, Fuceoruy have removed key features found on the Kidzlane product: Bluetooth connectivity, light up foot switches and reduced the number of foot controls on the mat. This also undercuts the price of the Kidzlane product with a visually similar product.

Target Audience

Gender neutral – not just for girls!

The Fuceoruy mat is marketed at both boys and girls. This is at odds with the majority of popular dance mats on Amazon which are aimed exclusively at girls. This exploits a gap in the market for a cheaper, gender-neutral dance mat which could be bought for a boy as well as a girl.

Fun for all the family

Marketing material [2] heavily emphasises that the product provides quality time between parents and children. Since the parents are the ones buying the product, this is aimed at them. It plays on their emotions as they want fun bonding activities to do with their child.



Packaging

Design for disposal

The box is cheaply made with stock images of children dancing, the required safety and age warnings, and a labelled diagram of the product functions. This minimal approach to the design of the box makes sense as this product is only sold on Amazon. Customers will not be buying the box off a shelf and will only see the box once they have bought the product and then it will likely be immediately discarded.

To assuage the opponents of throw-away culture the box claims it has been printed on recycled paper. Mitigating the environmental impact as this can further be recycled itself.

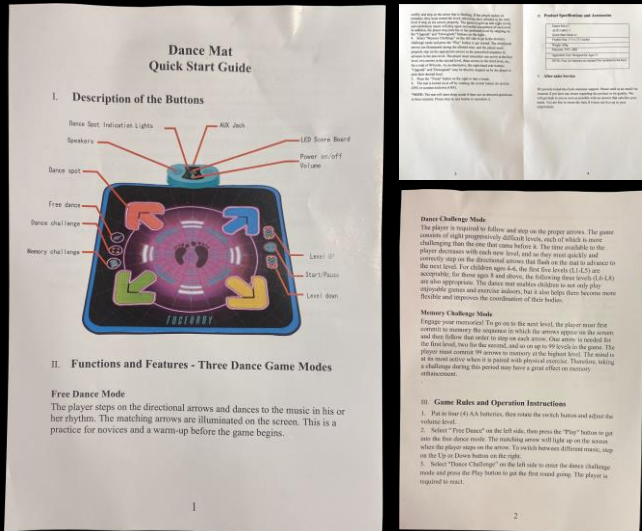
Marketing material online [2] shows that the mat can be folded and transported in a backpack; further reinforcing that the original box is disposable and not meant to be kept.

Also included is a 30cm 3.5 jack male-male cable [2] for connecting devices to the dance mat. Since the original box is not meant to be kept this ends up floating around the house and will inevitably be lost.



Instructions - Short but sufficient

One doubled sided A5 sheet constitutes the instructions included with the product. There is a labelled image of the dance mat, information about the 3 dance modes and some brief instructions about setting up the mat. Since there is no assembly (except batteries), and operation of the mat is very simple, these instructions are suitable and after the first use will probably be discarded with the box.

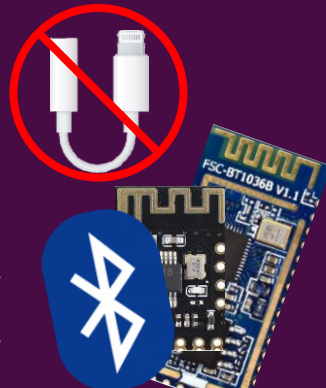


Improvements

Bluetooth

A 3.5mm audio jack is present but when most new mobile phones do not facilitate this it becomes slightly inconvenient to find a way to plug something in to play music. Many people may not anticipate needing an adapter [3] to plug a phone in.

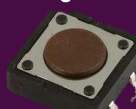
Adding Bluetooth to the product would incur a manufacturing cost. The Bluetooth modules shown are both available to buy on Alibaba [4] for around £2-3/product when bought in bulk. However, adding this feature would elevate the product above the competition, allowing it to be sold at a higher price, offsetting the extra cost as people would be willing to pay more for the premium feature.



Tactile Feedback

When stepping on the dance mat there is no physical feedback that a button has been pressed and sometimes a user thinks they have stepped on a switch when it hasn't activated; especially when 3 or 4 arrows must be stepped on in a short space of time. Adding tactile feedback to the foot switches would allow immediate feedback to the user for confidence that a button has been pressed.

The switch shown [5] is available for 18p/product when bought in bulk. The compromise of this is that it would require a rigid plate under each arrow – affecting how small the mat can be folded. It would also require 4-5 switches per button on the dance mat – again increasing manufacturing complexity and cost.



Decoy Marketing

A final improvement could be adding decoy products to the Fuceoruy range at lower and higher price ranges.

A dance mat priced £5 cheaper but with less attractive design and reduced functionality, as well as a dance mat priced £15 more but including premium features such as Bluetooth, tactile feedback or improved sound quality may not sell as well as the standard dance mat.

However, this would encourage more people to buy the standard product as it seems like the perfect compromise of features and cost.

